

Comparative Analysis of Role Language Translation in *Manga*:

A Case Study of the English Version of *Ranma ½*

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Although role language has a long-standing presence in Japanese literature, it had never been described from an academic perspective until the term was first introduced by Satoshi Kinsui in 2000. As a multidimensional phenomenon that intersects language, society, and cultural beliefs, it has been analysed by scholars from many different fields since then, but the topic continues to offer great opportunities for further discussion. This paper builds on previous work in this field and examines the presence of role language in the *manga* series by Rumiko Takahashi, *Ranma ½*, along with its translation into English. The linguistic analysis shows a possible correlation between the degree to which role language is employed in the original text and the likelihood of the peculiarities of a character's style of speech being reflected in the target text. This paper seeks to contribute to the study of the potential and limitations present in foreign languages at the moment of conveying the implications hinted by role language in fictional texts in Japanese.

Keywords: translation of *manga*, role language, character depiction, speech style, linguistic stereotypes

1 Introduction

Categorisation is a process that occurs naturally in daily communication. As humans, we organize the overwhelming flow of new information we are exposed to by classifying people according to defining traits, such as nationality, gender, race, occupation, or age. Despite the risks entailed by such simplistic conceptions of “the other”, by assuming that everyone who falls into a certain category shares common characteristics, we create mental shortcuts that help us make predictions and better comprehend the world around us.

Those characteristics are commonly referred to as *stereotypes* and are the cornerstone of the notion of role language. Of particular importance when analysing how stereotypes are activated is the dual process model of impression formation by Brewer (1988), which states that, when integrating information about a person, the information processing may differ depending on the perceiver's motives and their degree of involvement with the target. Thus, when the relationship between the perceiver and the target calls for no more than a superficial understanding of each other, the information handling stops at a stage of automatic processing. By contrast, when requiring a better grasp of the target, this process reaches a second stage, which includes both a “category-based processing mode” and a “person-based processing mode”.

During the first step, the target will be assigned to an existing category that is believed to match the target's features. In other words, a categorisation based on stereotypes is undertaken. During the second step, the target's individuating features are acknowledged, and information inconsistent with the initially assigned category may be incorporated as part of the overall impression. It must be said that not all individuals go through both steps, depending on the perceiver-target's relationship.

When examining the connection between the dual process model and role language, we discover that the same principles underpinning this theory may be used to explain example (1), drawn from Kinsui (2003: 30).

(1) Kyō-jū=ni yat-toi-tekure-tamae.

Today-during=in do-PRF-BEN-HON.IMP
‘Make sure you do it by the end of the day.’

Tamae in Japanese is a grammatical structure used for commands. In fiction, it is normally ascribed to characters who hold a certain level of power, which has resulted in the consolidation of *tamae* as a shaping feature of the role language for bosses in media (Kinsui 2014a). This “boss language” does not seek a realistic representation but a caricatured sketch of a boss, and it tends to be employed in background characters more often than in characters with relevance to the plot.

The same reasoning is applied in this example and in the model proposed by Brewer (1988). In fictional works, supporting characters intervene less frequently than protagonists, so the reader does not need to connect deeply with them or thoroughly understand their psyche. As in the dual process model, the perceiver and the target are not required to interact profoundly, so a description of the character type based on stereotypes is preferred to a personalized description, as it speeds up the information processing task performed by the reader. However, protagonists, as driving forces of the story, demand the readers’ self-identification, which raises the need for a more concrete characterization of them (Kinsui 2003). Thus, “boss language”, as in (1), operates as a linguistic code that embodies a given character type and all the connotations associated with that way of speaking without further explanation.

To describe these stereotypes employed in fiction, rooted in “category-based” descriptions to facilitate the comprehension of the story, Satoshi Kinsui (2000) coined the term “role language” (*yakuwarigo*). In his subsequent work, *Virtual Japanese: Enigmas of Role Language* (2003), he introduces the following description of the concept:

Role language is a set of language features (vocabulary, grammar, intonation, etc.) that evoke a specific character type (of a given age, gender, occupation, era, appearance, personality, etc.) (p. 205).

Interestingly, even though role language is constrained to the fictional framework and does not reflect a real way of speaking, all Japanese native speakers can identify, without a doubt, example (1) as the prototypical “boss language” in fiction. The reason behind this may be explained by using Vogler’s (1998) notion of *archetypes*. According to Vogler, several character types recur in all stories across cultures as “personified symbols of various human qualities” (p. 26). These basic patterns are the hero, the mentor, the threshold guardian, the herald, and the shapeshifter, among others, and they all revolve around the protagonist as the story progresses.

This correlation between a given archetype and a characteristic speech style is used frequently in Japanese media, especially in works aimed at younger audiences, as a deep com-

prehension of the story aligned with the “individual-specific processing mode” cannot be expected from them (Kinsui 2003). The continued repetition of this scheme contributes to the strengthening of cultural stereotypes in society and the conservation of role language in fiction.

In light of the above, the following can be concluded: role language is a given speech style that cannot be extrapolated to reality and which is employed in literary texts to depict a specific archetype. With this understanding of role language, let’s now consider how it works inside a text and how it is used by the author as a means to facilitate the reader’s comprehension of the story.

Yamaguchi (2011) uses the terms “microcosmic communication” and “macrocosmic communication” to refer to the two types of conversational exchange that occur in fictional works. “Microcosmic communication” refers to the conversational exchange held between two characters (e.g., Character A and Character B in Figure 1), whereas “macrocosmic communication” refers to the conversational exchange held between the author and the reader. Role language can therefore be said to target both the reader (who is located outside the framework of the fictional world) and the characters inside the story at the same time. Given this precondition, it is not easy to maintain the same level of naturalness as in real conversation, and the understanding of the reader is normally prioritized over the authenticity of the dialogues (Yamaguchi 2011).

“*Kyōjū ni yattoite kure tamae*”, as in (1), might undermine the story’s veracity, but it is accepted as a tacit agreement between the reader and the writer as a fast and efficient method of delivering information.

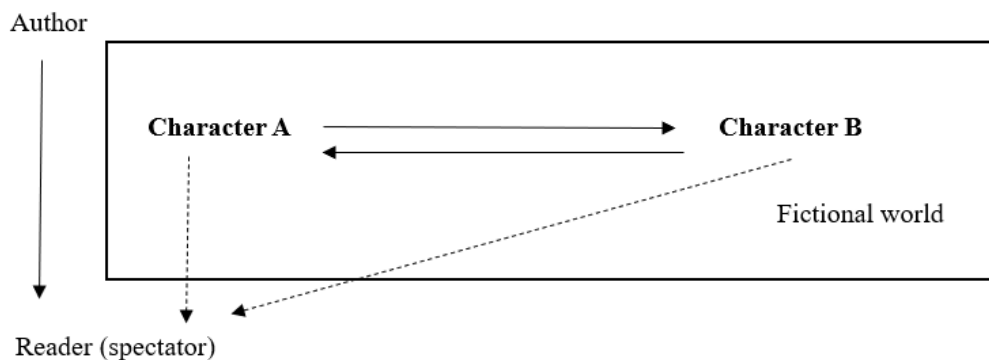


Figure 1: The two types of communication observed in role language (adapted from Yamaguchi 2011: 29)

Since Kinsui first identified role language in 2000, this phenomenon has been examined from both linguistic and social perspectives. In the field of Translation Studies, the works of Kinsui (2011), Yamakido (2019), and Ivarsson (2021) have been instrumental in understanding the function of role language at the moment of constructing a story in Japanese and how it has been rendered in other languages, especially English.

Kinsui (2011) states that, used properly, role language can be an important weapon for the translator. It provides information about the character type, the background, or the intention behind the work. However, when overused, role language can become a yoke, as it can alter the overall impression of the work, distorting it into something of little depth and devoid of content. As the perception towards role language changes over time, it is the translator's responsibility to read the intention behind the original work and transmit it in the target language (and culture) in a way that fits not only the literary style of the work but also contemporary values and trends.

For their part, Yamakido (2019) and Ivarsson (2021) examine translations from Japanese to English and conclude that some traits of the character's speech style can be recreated in the target text, but they often appear in forms that differ from the original. This is because the translator's range of action is constrained by the characteristics of the English language, with naturalness being a precondition that shapes the translator's choices.

This paper builds on previous research and examines the role language present in the first four volumes of the manga series *Ranma ½* and its translation into English. The focus is on the relation between the "role language degree" of a character's speech in the source text and the extent to which the peculiarities of that character's speech are replicated in the target text, as this correlation has not been studied sufficiently to date.

This paper first introduces the concept of "role language degree" along with the characters' categorisations by class, as proposed by Kinsui (2017). Thereafter, the main traits of the role language typology will be examined, with an emphasis on "male language", "female language", "elderly male language", "*aruyo kotoba*", and "broken Japanese". Finally, the translation will be compared with the source text, and the strategies used for the conveyance of role language will be identified and discussed.

2 Framework of analysis

2.1 Role language degree

Role language is not a ponderable, fixed set of traits that characterizes speech in fiction. It should rather be interpreted as a spectrum ranging from subtle to exaggerated, depending on the author's intention. This becomes apparent when the following two utterances extracted from Kinsui (2003: 68) are considered in parallel.

(2) Sono hi=wa taihen yoi otenki=deat-ta.
 That day=TOP very good weather=COP-PST
 'On that day, the weather was really fine.'

(3) Kyo=wa taihen ii otenki=da-ne?
 Today=TOP very good weather=COP-PRT.TAG
 'The weather is really fine today, isn't it?'

Example (2) is a sample of written language. It fails to provide information regarding the speaker and does not evoke any specific character. On the contrary, (3) represents a more informal speech style. Here, the combination of the copula *da* and the particle *ne* suggests that the speaker might be a man. By analysing these two examples together, it is possible to conclude that the first case exhibits a role language degree of zero, whereas the second case hints at some features of the speaker, but the information supplied is still very restricted. This means a low degree of role language, as only the character's gender may be surmised through this utterance.

Kinsui refers to this gradation as “role language degree”: the extent to which a speech style succeeds in summoning a specific character type. On that basis, “written language” should be placed at the bottom of the scale, whereas a private or informal speech style may be granted a level of 1, as shown in Figure 2.

Degree of Role Language

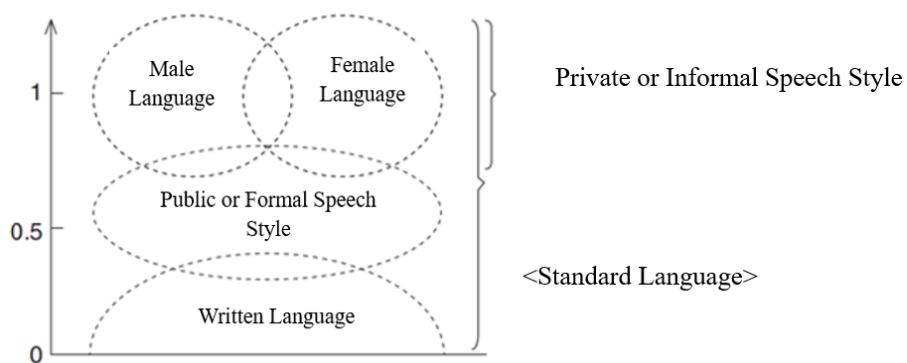


Figure 2: Degree of role language (adapted from Kinsui 2003: 69)

A degree above 1 reflects a more prominent use of role language and a manner of speaking that is distant from the standard. This results in a more concrete depiction of the character, as observed in example (4).

- (4) *Mattaku* *ja.* *Shikashi* *tenki-yohō=wa,*
 Really COP but weather-forecast=TOP
ashita=wa *ame=kamoshiren=to* *it-teot-ta-zo.*
 tomorrow=TOP rain=might=QUOT say-PRF-PST-PRT

‘Yeah, totally. But the weather forecast was saying that it might rain tomorrow, you know.’ (Kinsui 2003: 69)

Here, elements such as the copula *ja* instead of *da*, the negative form *ka mo shiren* instead of the usual grammar pattern *ka mo shirenai*, the progressive form *-te otta* instead of *-teita*, and the final particle *zo* represent an unconventional use of the language, as they are traditionally associated with elderly male characters in fiction.

Let’s now consider the concept of “role language degree” in connection with the dual process model of impression formation mentioned earlier. As previously mentioned, a “person-based” description is expected for those characters with a fundamental role in the story, as the reader

must be able to empathise with them. To this end, the main protagonists tend to use role language degree of $1 + \alpha$, that is, a standard speech style devoid of the artificiality of written language (Kinsui 2003). Kinsui (2017: 246) suggests three categories (or “classes”) to which characters may be allocated depending on their significance to the plot and the degree to which they make use of role language.

Class 1: Protagonists or co-protagonists. They appear frequently and show a detailed internal description. The language employed by them is often based on standard language and displays a low degree of role language.

Class 2: Important characters categorized as archetypes: mentor, ally, trickster, etc. Their internal description is not as rich as in the case of Class 1 characters. In terms of language, they normally use prototypical role language; however, at times they may exhibit a unique way of speaking.

Class 3: Characters that only appear once and are rarely referred to by name. Generally, they use the safest (prototypical) role language.

These three classes can be applied in the analysis of *Ranma ½*. Thus, characters will be categorized under these three groups at the moment of revisiting the role language used in the Japanese version of the *manga*.

2.2 Categorisation of role language

Role language may be explained as the bond between alterable parameters: a certain speech style (defined by the vocabulary, grammar, syntax, or intonation of the speaker) and a character type (determined by the age, gender, occupation, period, personality, appearance, etc. of the speaker). Since these parameters depend on the knowledge the Japanese language community has about certain cultural stereotypes and social groups, trying to grasp and fully classify role language is an impossible task.

In this light, in his 2014 work, “*Yakuwarigo*”: *Shōjiten*, Kinsui attempts to elaborate on a possible categorisation of role language based on six social and cultural subgroups. An adaptation of this categorisation scheme as summarized in Kinsui & Yamakido (2015) is represented in Table 1.

Of these, “male language”, “female language”, “elderly male language”, “*aruyo kotoba*”, and “broken language” are the types of role language identified in *Ranma ½*. Next, the main features of these five types will be described in line with the research of Honda (1990), Okamoto (1995), Kinsui (2003; 2014a; 2014b), and Nakamura (2007).

The following are some of the features that define the current “male language” in Japanese:

- **Personal pronouns**

Boku, ore, oira, kisama or *omae*.

- **Final particles**

Plain form + *yo*, i-adjective + *yo*, *da/ da ne/ da yo/ da yone*, *-ze*, *-zo*, imperative form (+*yo*).

- **Others**

Interjections (*oi, oya, kora*), frequent use of the imperative form, sound changes, vowel merging, and phoneme elision.

Table 1: Categorisation of role language (adapted from Kinsui & Yamakido 2015, p. 31)

Subgroup	Type
gender	male language , female language , gay male language
age/generation	elderly male language , elderly female language, middle-aged male language, young speaker's language, boy's language, schoolgirl language, gal language
social class/occupation	wealthy woman's language, young-lady-from-a-good-family language, boss language, formal-speech language, king/nobles language, powerful person's language, butler's language, army language, comedian's language, doctor's language, (young-)dancing-girl-of-Kyōto language, maid language, <i>yakuza</i> (gangster) language, delinquent-girl's language, <i>sumo</i> -wrestler language
region/nationality/ethnicity	Osaka language/Kansai language, rural language, Okinawan language, Owari language, Tosa language, Nagoya language, Kyūshū language, Kyōto language, <i>arimasu</i> -language, aruyo-language , pidgin, broken language , Chinese language
pre-modern	Edo language, princess language, Kyōto-Ōsaka language, court-noble language, live-in student language, merchant-class language, <i>ninja</i> language, <i>samurai</i> language, prostitute language, <i>jii</i> (old chaperon) language, downtown language
imaginary creatures	alien language, god language, ghost language

2.2.1 Male language

To explain the roots of “male language”, it is necessary to introduce the figure of *shosei* in the Meiji era. *Shosei* refers to those students who would leave their hometowns to attend schools in major cities, doing household chores in exchange for board and lodging. Their language was a fusion of Tokyo and western Japanese dialects, along with some other characteristics such as the use of *boku*/*wagahai*/*kimi* as personal pronouns, *tamae*/*beshi* as imperative expressions, and Sino-Japanese and foreign words. *Boku* and *tamae* were expressions originally used by the men of the samurai class, so it becomes apparent that this “student language” (which eventually consolidated as “boy’s language”) was also influenced by the “samurai language”.

2.1.2 Female language

The origin of “female language” can be observed in the Muromachi era, specifically, in the use of “*nyōbō kotoba*” by court ladies. “*Nyōbō kotoba*”, or “court lady’s language”, was a speech style mainly characterized by the addition of *o-* at the beginning of words, as it sounded more delicate and reserved. Some examples of this speech style include terms like *onaka*, *ohiya*, and *oishii*. Since it was considered elegant and feminine, “*Nyōbō kotoba*” quickly gained popularity among the women of the samurai class and the *shōgun* families.

Later, in the Meiji era, education became compulsory for all citizens, and women enrolled in schools for the first time, which led to the formation of “female students’ language” (“*jōgakusei kotoba*”). Its major feature is the use of *teyo dawa*, a way of speaking strongly criticized back then, as it was perceived as vulgar. Nevertheless, *teyo dawa* language spread to elementary schools, then to girls’ high schools, and finally to older women. Its proliferation in society laid the foundation for the “female language” as we know it today.

Listed below are some of the features that define the current “female language” in Japanese:

- **Personal pronouns**

Atashi, atai, anata.

- **Final particles**

Wa↑, wa ne, wa yo, wa yone, noun+no, na-adjective+no, no ne, no yone, no yo, kashira, plain form+ no, i-adjective+ no.

- **Others**

Use of polite expressions, interjections (*ara, ma↑*).

2.1.3 Elderly male language

“Elderly male language” can be traced back to the Edo era, when elderly men (doctors and scholars in particular) would dress up their speech with old-fashioned expressions that endowed it with a conservative style. This refined manner of speaking was exaggerated in fictional works and prevailed in theatre during the Meiji era.

With the emergence of new genres, the image of “elderly male language” was reinforced, and more role language types arose. These are “doctor’s language” (“*hakasego*”) and “elderly female language” (“*obaasango*”), as well as “king’s language” (“*ōsamago*”) and “princess language” (“*ohimesamago*”), with which they share common traits like the use of the copula *ja*.

Listed below are some of the features that define the current “elderly male language” in Japanese:

- **Personal pronouns**

washi, wagahai.

- **Final particles**

wai, nō.

- **Others**

Copula *ja* to express assertion, negative forms that deviate from the standard, such as *shiran* / *shiranu*, *oru* as an expression of existence; progressive form *-te oru* / *-toru*.

2.1.4 Aruyo kotoba and broken Japanese

“Aruyo kotoba” is related to non-Japanese beings, in other words, what Kinsui (2003) calls *ijin* (different person). Kinsui classifies *ijin* into three groups:

- **Foreigners:** Western (white), black, Chinese, etc.
- **People from former times:** Warriors, nobility.
- **Beings different from people:** Gods, ghosts, fairies, aliens, robots, etc.

Among these, only the Chinese stereotypical speech style is reflected in *Ranma ½*, so this is the only category that will be explained here in detail.

To trace the beginning of “aruyo kotoba”, it is necessary to first define the term “pidgin”. “Pidgin” refers to a language with simplified vocabulary and grammar that emerges spontaneously as a temporary solution to enable contact in a place where more than two languages coexist. An example of this is the Yokohama dialect, a pidginized Japanese which appeared in Yokohama after Japan opened its borders at the end of the Edo era. The Yokohama dialect is similar to “aruyo kotoba” in the use of the expression *yoroshii* for commands, but it differs in its use of the ending *arimasu* instead of *aru*. Thus, although the origin of “aruyo kotoba” is not clear, it may be found in the chapter on “Nankinized Nippon” in a parodic book titled *Exercises in the Yokohama Dialect* (published in the Meiji era), where the use of *aru* is recorded. When examining documents from that time, it can be understood that the Yokohama dialect was used to depict the stereotypical language of foreigners, which contributed to the development of a distinct role language in fiction.

Listed below are some of the features that define the current “aruyo kotoba” in Japanese:

- **Personal pronouns**
None.
- **Final particles**
Aru as an expression of assertion, *yoroshii* for commands and suggestions.
- **Others**
Ellipsis of conjunctions and particles such as *ga* or *wo*.

With regard to “broken Japanese”, Yoda (2011) adds that the presence of mother tongue, the insertion of *moras*, and expressions in *katakana* characterize the stereotypical broken Japanese of foreign characters.

In §3 and §4, the speech styles of the characters in the Japanese text will be examined under the framework of analysis presented here. Thereafter, the target text will be analysed to explore the relationship between the degree of role language used in the source text and the approach taken in the English translation.

3 Role language in the Japanese version of *Ranma ½*

Ranma ½ is a *manga* series created by Rumiko Takahashi, who debuted in 1978 with *Kattena Yatsura*. Over the course of more than four decades, she earned both critical acclaim and readers’ rec-

ognition in the field of *shōnen manga*, which targets young boys. *Ranma ½* appeared on the scene in 1987 and was later adapted into an *anime* by Fuji Television in 1989. The *manga* consisted of 38 volumes, while the *anime* comprised 161 episodes.

The story revolves around Ranma Saotome, a 16-year-old boy who is an expert in martial arts. In a training journey with his father in China, he is cursed to become a girl when touched by cold water, and to return to his real appearance when exposed to hot water. Upon his return to Japan, he discovers that he is engaged to Akane, the youngest of the three daughters of the Tendo Family, whom both father and son will have to live with from that moment on.

Hereafter, fourteen characters from the first four volumes of this series are categorized according to the three classes set by Kinsui, depending on their importance in the plot.

Class 1: Ranma and Akane.

Their speech styles may be classified as “male language” and “female language”, respectively. Ranma’s most-used personal pronoun is *ore*, which is traditionally related to a much higher level of masculinity than *boku* (Kinsui 2014a). Additionally, Ranma’s speech is marked by the use of final particles such as *da* (*da yo*, *da yone*), *ze*, and *zo* (all identified by Okamoto (1995) as very masculine expressions), as well as sound changes, vowel merging, and phoneme elision. Incidentally, his role language is not modified when he transforms into a woman. It is possible to assert that Ranma portrays the archetypal role of the strong male protagonist in a *shōnen manga*.

In contrast, Akane employs the conventional way of speaking expected of women. She refers to herself as *atashi*, a form reserved for young girls. Her speech often includes particles such as *wa* (*wa ne*, *wa yo*, *wa yone*) and *no ne*, *no yone*, *no yo*, which Okamoto (1995) describes as extremely feminine.

Class 2: All the secondary characters except for the Jusenkyo guide, namely Akane and Ranma’s relatives, classmates, friends, and enemies.

Akane’s sisters are Kasumi and Nabiki. Although both Kasumi and Nabiki use the typical “female language” also observed in Akane, Kasumi’s speech is distinguished by a more recurrent use of formal expressions than her sisters’, as demonstrated in the following example.

(5) <i>Chūgoku</i>	<i>zendo</i>	<i>shugyō-jō</i>	<i>mokuroku...?</i>	<i>Ojisama</i>
China	whole.land	training-place	inventory	uncle
<i>Chūgoku-go=ga</i>		<i>yome-nakat-ta-ndesu-yo-ne.</i>		
Chinese-language=NOM		read-NEG-PST-COP-PRT-PRT		

An inventory of training places in China...? Uncle, you couldn’t read Chinese, right?

When referring to Ranma’s father, Kasumi uses the term *ojisama* instead of *ojisan*. While both can be translated as “uncle”, the former conveys a higher degree of respect than the latter. Likewise, Kasumi shows a preference for the form *desu/masu*, a common verb conjugation in formal conversation. The reason behind this might be that Kasumi is perceived as a mother figure in the family after her mother’s passing, so her use of Japanese is to reflect the maturity and modesty expected for that status.

For Akane and Ranma's fathers, both Genma and Sōun use the typical "elderly male language" of old men in fiction. This implies the use of the personal pronoun *washi*, the copula *ja*, *oru* as an expression of existence, the progressive form *-te oru/ -toru*, and some negative forms that deviate from the standard, as observed in example (6) by Genma, where the form *naoran* (*naoru*=to heal) is used instead of the standard *naoranai*. This characteristic is particular to the "elderly male language" in fiction, but it can also be heard in the contemporary Western Japanese dialect.

- (6) *Mada kubi=ga naora-n-no-ka?*
 still neck=NOM heal-NEG-NOM-Q
 'Isn't your neck healed yet?'

Regarding Akane and Ranma's friends and foes, seven characters fall into these categories: Kunō, Dr. Tōfū, Ryōga, Mikado, Kodachi, Azusa, and Shampoo. Kunō, Dr. Tōfū, Ryōga, and Mikado employ "male language", Kodachi and Azusa speak "female language", and Shampoo uses "broken Japanese".

Of all these, it is worth explaining the speech styles of Kunō, Kodachi, Azusa, and Shampoo, as they present some unique features that go beyond what is expected for their role languages.

Kunō is the captain of the *kendo* team. Despite his talent for martial arts, he is not particularly recognized for being an excellent student at Fūrinkan High School. Unable to grasp that both male Ranma and female Ranma are the same person, he sees Ranma as his enemy in his male form but pursues him as a romantic interest in his female form. Kunō's manner of speaking is "male language," imbued with Japanese words of Chinese origin and old expressions that endow his speech with a feeling of affectation that brings the character close to the stereotypical image of *samurai* in fiction. Examples (7) and (8) illustrate this:

- (7) *Wasure-nu-uchi=ni, memo-shi-teoka-neba!!*
 forget-NEG-while=in note-do-PRF-must
 'I must take notes before I forget it!!'

Unlike the case of Genma, the negative form *wasurenu* instead of the standard *wasurenai* (*wasureru*= to forget) in (7) is not commonly used in modern Japanese. Instead, it is a negative auxiliary that can be traced back to classical Japanese. Something similar happens to the grammar pattern *-neba naranai*, whose meaning is "have to/ must", and which corresponds to a literary usage of Japanese rarely seen in conversation.

It is also worth mentioning Kodachi, who is Kunō's younger sister and the captain of the gymnastics team of the St. Bacchus's School for Girls. She is arrogant, as well as dishonest, particularly in competitive situations. With regard to her manner of speaking, she employs "female language" along with an extremely embellished use of words, intended to reflect both her cold personality and her position on the gymnastics team, a sport traditionally associated with elegance.

- (8) *Ikaga=desu?* *Kondo=no* *shiai=de* *Ranma-sama=wo*
 how=COP next=GEN match=LOC Ranma-HON=ACC
kakeru *to=iu=no-wa.* ***Ho ho ho ho ho!***
 Wager QUOT=say=NOM-TOP ONOM

‘How about this? We will wager Ranma in the next competition. Ho, ho, ho, ho, ho!’

In (8), not only is the *desu/masu* form used, but also some other expressions, such as *ikaga* or the laughter *ho, ho, ho, ho, ho*, which are traditionally linked to a feminine and classy way of speaking. This constructs a well-defined speech style for Kodachi that comprises features that challenge the limits of traditional “female language”.

The character type portrayed by Kodachi shares many traits with Azusa. Azusa is a young girl, an expert in martial-arts ice skating, with a spoiled personality and a behaviour suggestive of kleptomania. She also uses “female language” with honorific expressions and formal Japanese, as well as the form *desu/masu + koto*, a pattern observed in “young lady from a good family language”, as seen in example (9).

- (9) *Shumoku=wa* *pea-sukēto* ***desu.*** *Watashi=ga*
 Category=TOP pair-skating COP 1.SG=NOM
kat-tara *Sharurotto=wo* ***kaeshi-teitadakimasu-koto- yo!***
 win-COND Charlotte=ACC return-BEN.HON-NOM-PRT

‘The category is pair skating. If I win, I will get Charlotte back!’

Shampoo is also a young girl, but as she is originally from China and cannot communicate freely in Japanese, her manner of speaking is characterized by the omission of conjunctions and particles, the insertion of her mother tongue, and the elision of geminate consonants and long vowels. This may be defined as “broken Japanese”.

- (10) *Anata=[wa]* *onna-teki* *Ranma=[wo]* *korosu.* *Watashi=[wa]*
 2.SG=TOP woman-ATTR Ranma=ACC kill 1.SG=TOP
119-shampoo=[wo] *watasu.* *Kōkan-jōken.* *Yoku*
 119-shampoo=ACC give exchange-condition well
wakara-nai=kedo *waka[t]-ta.*
 understand-NEG=but understand-PST

‘If you kill female Ranma, I’ll give you shampoo 119. These are the conditions for exchange. I don’t understand, but got it.’ (lit. ‘You kill female Ranma. I give you shampoo 119. Conditions for exchange. I don’t understand, but understood.’)

Strictly speaking, the elision of geminate consonants and long vowels (like in *waka[t]ta* in 10) is neither a defining characteristic of “broken Japanese” nor “*aruyo kotoba*”, but it is a common trait for all the Chinese characters that appear in *Ranma ½*. Kinsui (2014b) states that this feature of the pidgin Japanese created by Rumiko Takahashi aims at increasing the realism of the work by reflecting a real phenomenon observed in some foreign speakers of Japanese.

Class 3: Class 3 only includes the Jusenkyo guide. He is a Chinese tourist guide with no apparent name who appears occasionally in the *manga* just to explain the curse at the training ground at Jusenkyo. His role language matches the features expected for the prototypical

“*aruyo kotoba*”, like *aru* for assertion and *yoroshii* for commands and suggestions. Besides this, his speech also contains grammatical mistakes, as illustrated by the use of *ne* in example (11).

- (11) A, *okyaku-san* *nani* *suru=ne!*
 INTJ customer-HON what do=PRT
 ‘Ah, customer, what are you doing?’ (lit. ‘Ah, customer, what are you doing, right?’)

Ne is a final particle in Japanese that intends to seek agreement or confirmation from the listener. Therefore, example (11) does not reflect an appropriate usage. With regards to this, Yoda (2011) explains that the use of non-standard forms can be interpreted as representative features of foreign characters in fiction, even though it is not included as a characteristic trait of “*aruyo kotoba*”.

In this section, the role language used by the fourteen characters identified in the first four volumes of *Ranma ½* has been briefly described. This information is summarized (along with representative lines of each character) in Table 2, created using de Nazareth (2019) as a reference.

Table 2: Role language in the Japanese version of *Ranma ½*

Character	Role language	Line
Ranma	male language	<i>Ryōga, nan dayo, konna yonaka ni... mata. Ee kagen ni shiroyo.</i>
Akane	female language	<i>Ne, dōjō mi ni ikanai? Atashi Akane. Naka yoku shiyōne.</i>
Kasumi	female language	<i>Saotome ojisama, anmari desuwa.</i>
Nabiki	female language	<i>Nna koto bakka yatteru kara matomoni motenai noyo.</i>
Genma	elderly male language	<i>Mada kubi ga naoran no ka?</i>
Sōun	elderly male language	<i>Saotome oyako wa musha shugyō no tabi ni dete otte nā.</i>
Kunō	male language	<i>Wasurenu uchi ni, memo shite okaneba!!</i>
Dr. Tōfū	male language	<i>Ano ko, hontō ni ii ko dayo.</i>
Ryōga	male language	<i>Okiro, Ranma. Ore da. Ryōga da. Shōbu shiro.</i>
Mikado	male language	<i>Ee kagen ni shinaika, baka onna!!</i>
Kodachi	female language	<i>Ikagadesu? Kondo no shiai de Ranma sama wo kakeru to iu nowa. Ho ho ho ho ho!</i>
Azusa	female language	<i>Shumoku wa pea sukēto desu. Watashi ga kattara, Sharu-rotto wo kaeshite itadakimasu koto yo!</i>
Shampoo	broken Japanese	<i>Anata [wa] onna-teki Ranma [wo] korosu. Watashi [wa] 119 shampoo [wo] watasu. Kōkan jōken. Yoku wakaranai kedo, waka[t]ta.</i>
Jusenkyo Guide	<i>aruyo kotoba</i>	<i>Nigeru yoroshi, okyaku san.</i>

4 Role language in the English version of *Ranma ½*

Translating is not the simple conveyance of words and sentences from one language to another, but a delicate mediation between cultures, in which the translator must weigh the loss and gain in meaning that come with their decisions.

According to Yamakido (2019), the more distant two languages or cultures are, the more difficult it is to find a suitable equivalence for more than one level (vocabulary, grammar, text structure, etc.). Role language is a multifaceted phenomenon; not only does it operate on many different levels within a text, but it also summons the social stereotypes a language community has toward a particular group. On this basis, the translation of role language faces two main problems. First, as how role language is expressed depends on the distinctive features of a given language, the shape taken by role language is expected to change from one language to another. Second, due to its social and cultural dimension, role language will not always have an expression in the target language that matches perfectly with what is implied in the original text (Kinsui 2011).

In the case of the Japanese language, the creation of role language is facilitated by a vast variety of personal pronouns and an endless list of final particles, but this option is not available in English. For this reason, it is not unreasonable to think that, at the moment of translating a given speech style into English, the limitations established by the language itself will determine how it is conveyed and whether the nuances of the original are preserved or altered.

This difficulty inherent in the translation of Japanese role language has been studied from various perspectives so far, with contrastive analysis as one example. However, as a relatively recent field of study, it is safe to say that it has not been explored sufficiently. By analysing the conveyance of role language in foreign languages, it is possible to grasp not only how linguistic stereotypes are altered and adapted to fit other cultures' archetypes, but it also provides an opportunity to reflect upon the nature of the Japanese language and what features of the fictionalised orality in Japanese are unique and which ones are shared with other literary traditions.

In this section, the translation of *Ranma ½* into English will be examined to grasp the differences between the characters' speech in the Japanese and English versions. The edition under analysis, brought by the American entertainment company Viz Media in 2014, is a joint translation by Gerard Jones and Matt Thorn, who were also in charge of the North American version of *Maison Ikkoku*, a previous *manga* work by the same author.

Through this approach, the translation strategies used in the English version of the *manga* will be identified and contrasted with the "role language degree" and the classes ascribed to the characters in the original. The aim is to find a connection between the original text in Japanese and the likelihood for a specific role language to be reflected in the translation.

4.1 Male language

In general, there are no expressions in the English version that can be categorized as "male language", so we consider that this role language does not have a counterpart in the translation.

Although the intrinsic nature of English hampers the depiction of gender, it does allow a clear rendering of the register. Most of the male characters that appear in *Ranma ½* are teenagers close to their twenties, and their speaking manner in Japanese is consequently informal. In English, this characteristic is recreated by the use of phrasal verbs (“put up with”, “cut out”, “hang on”, “sneak up”, etc.) and contractions (“gotcha”, “ain’t”, “gotta”, “leggo”, etc.).

For Kunō, whose speech was described as “male language” despite being dressed with words of Chinese origin and old-fashioned expressions in Japanese, there are some solutions in the translation that are worth mentioning. In example (12), (a) refers to the Japanese original expression along with a literal translation of the content, while (b) refers to the official rendering into English found in the analysed edition.

- (12) a. *Minnakimi=ni* *kat-ta* *akatsukini=wa*,
 everybody2.SG=DAT win-PST on.the.occasion=TOP
kōsai=wo *mōshikomu* *tsumori=rashii=ga...*
 relationship=ACC request intention=seem=but
 ‘Everybody intends to ask you out when defeating you.’

- b. “Evidently each of them intends to ask you out, Akane... On the **morn** that he finally defeats you.”

Leaving aside the fact that the Japanese expression *akatsuki niwa* is a set phrase that could be translated as “in the event of” and, consequently it has nothing to do with morning, excerpt (12) is a perfect example of how the translators have been able to grasp the intention underneath the character and adapt his speech by making use of the possibilities offered by the English language. “Morn”, which is an alternative form of “morning”, is considered literary and, therefore, not appropriate for conversation. However, here it helps recreate the samurai-like appearance and attitude of Kunō in the original Japanese. Something similar can be seen in (13).

- (13) a. *Boku=kara* *nanoro-u!!*
 1.SG.M=from introduce.oneself-VOL
 ‘I will introduce myself.’

- b. ***Mine I shall give!***

With regard to the use of “shall” in contemporary American English, Samodra & Bram (2022) explain that this modal verb is frequently used in rules, regulations, and instructions, so it is related to more formal settings than “will”. Building on this, example (13) presents a word order that is uncommon in contemporary English. This might be a conscious decision made by the translators with the intention to simulate the impression of the Japanese text.

In summary, it is possible to assert that even though “male language” has no direct equivalent in the target text, there are other qualities of the characters that manage to be incorporated in the translation.

4.2 Female language

As with “male language”, there is no direct equivalent for “female language” in the English translation. The colloquial register of the female characters is replicated by the use of contractions (“gotcha”, “c’mere”, “y’know”, “kay”, etc.), but to a lesser degree than in the case of the male characters. Incidentally, the speech style by Kasumi (which had been described as slightly more formal than her sister’s) also contains contractions, but only in the subject, as in “I’m”, “you’re”, “he’s”, etc.

Likewise, in the case of Kodachi, in which the refinement of gymnastics also permeates her use of language, the translation to English is characterized by modal verbs such as “shall” and “may” and words that denote a certain degree of formality: “restate”, “wager”, “imprudence”, “thus”, etc. In addition to this, there are several scenes in which the translators alter the original text to boost the drama and theatricality attached to this character, as in (14):

- (14) a. *Jama=ga* *hait-te* *zannen=desu.*
 obstruction=NOM enter-and unfortuate=COP
 ‘What a shame an obstacle appeared.’

b. ***Such tragic timing!***

The depiction of Kodachi does not seek to be realistic. She is always portrayed wearing a gymnastics leotard, and her personality changes abruptly, going from extremely sweet and complacent when in the presence of male Ranma, to sadistic when in the presence of women. This, along with a speaking manner marked by a slightly higher role language degree than the standard “female language”, makes her figure parodic. This frees the translators from the constraints imposed by naturalness and allows them to engage creatively with the text.

Thus, “such tragic timing” deviates from the original *Jama ga haitte zannen desu* (= ‘What a shame an obstacle appeared’) in terms of meaning and alters the perspective of the utterance, but it contributes to the construction of Kodachi’s dramatized and very comic-like use of language in English.

As for Azusa, as explained before, her speaking style contains honorific expressions and language patterns consistent with the “young lady from a good family language”. The strategy chosen in English involves the repeated use of the adjective “widdle”, a mocking way to say “small”, and spelling alterations. Example (15) illustrates this.

- (15) a. *Anata=wa* *Sharurotto=desu-ne!?* *Sono* *kubiwa=wa,*
 2.SG=TOP Charlotte=COP-PRT.TAG that collar=TOP
 Azusa-chan=ga *Sharurotto=ni* *age-ta* *mono=desu=wa.*
 Azusa-HON=NOM Charlotte=DAT give-PST thing=COP=PRT
 ‘You’re Charlotte, right? That is the collar Azusa gave to Charlotte.’

b. “You’re my **widdle** Charlotte, aren’t you? That collar! **Widdle** Azusa gave a **widdle** collar to her **Charwotte!**”

Example (15) shows both the use of “widdle” and spelling alterations, as in “Charwotte”. The repeated use of an adjective such as “widdle” aligns with the intention of the translators

to infantilize Azusa's way of speaking, even though those connotations are not necessarily attached to the role language used by her in the original work. Therefore, this decision may be triggered by another element present in her speech, which is believed to be the employment of "Azusa" instead of the first-person singular pronoun. In Japanese, the use of someone's proper name is a phenomenon relatively common among children, but it comes across as unusual in the words of a teenager. This characteristic of Azusa's Japanese speech style together with her appearance in the *manga* (a long-haired brunette with wide, innocent eyes and a delicate figure) give rise to a more childish interpretation of the character by the translators.

Similarly, the spelling alteration "Charwotte" may be founded in an actual speech disorder known as rhotacism, which involves replacing difficult sounds like "r" with "w". This speech impairment has been widely exploited in fiction to portray characters in a particular light, with childishness and affectedness being two of the most commonly associated traits (Foulkes & Docherty 2000). The use of rhotacism is also remarkable for its comic effect in media. One classic example of this is Elmer Fudd in the Looney Tunes cartoons, whose speech exhibits a systematic substitution of "r" with "w", such as in "wabbit" (rabbit), or "scwewy" (screwy). Langowska (2023) suggests that there must be a correlation between Elmer Fudd's speech disorder and his traits of character, as rhotacism helps construct a villain that, far from inspiring fear among the audience, comes across as clumsy and consequently laughable. This aligns perfectly with the tone of the cartoons.

For Azusa, this small sample of rhotacism in the word "Charlotte" may be understood as part of a translation strategy in the process of sketching the character as an infantile and snobbish teenager. However, it is debatable if this representation of her alters the original understanding of the character.

Another example of an alteration in the pronunciation is observed in (16).

- (16) a. *Kōsan-suru=nara* *ima=no=uchi=desu-wa-yo.*
 Surrender-do=COND now=GEN=within=COP-PRT-PRT
- Sharurotto,* *o-heya=wo* *tsukut-te* *mat-temasu=kara-ne.*
 Charlotte HON-room=ACC make-and wait-GER=because-PRT
- 'If you're going to surrender, this is the moment. Charlotte, I'll prepare a room and wait for you.'
- b. "If you're going to **back dow-own**, do it **now-ow**! Widdle Charlotte! Mommy will make a widdle bed and wait for you."

Here, *kōsan suru nara ima no uchi desu wa yo*, a sentence that could be translated as "if you're going to surrender, this is the moment", is conveyed as "if you're going to back dow-own, do it now-ow" in the English text. By playing with the sonority of the words, as well as introducing additional elements (such as the word "mommy"), the text loses part of its original weight and Azusa is again depicted as a young girl with an unusual, childlike way of speaking.

Since Azusa's role language in Japanese conforms mainly to the features of "female language" and "young lady from a good family language", there might be a slight mismatch between

Azusa's personality as suggested in the Japanese text and in the English translation. However, this kind of alteration in the translated version may help endow her with a well-defined, comical personality that comes across as enjoyable to readers.

4.3 Elderly male language

The “elderly male language” used by Genma and Sōun is reinterpreted in English through the use of expressions typically associated with a high register. In the example by Genma (17), *omoidasu* is translated as “recall” instead of “remember”, a form typically associated with a more refined way of speaking. Likewise, “gasp in disbelief” represents a variation in the form of the Japanese text, resulting in the loss of the original message *kamiwaza... to iu hoka wa nai* (= ‘it could only be a miracle’) in the English version. Leaving aside the question of whether this proposal is adequate or not, “gasp in disbelief” matches both the personality and appearance of Genma, as he is not expected to speak the same way as the rest of the characters, who are much younger than him.

- (17) a. *Are=wa* *mattaku ima* *omoidashi-temo,* *kamiwaza*
 that=TOP indeed now remember-even miracle
 to=iu *hoka=wa-nai!*
 QUOT=say other=TOP-NEG
 ‘Now that I remember it, it could only be a miracle.’
 b. “Even now as I **recall** it, I can only **gasp in disbelief!**”

Also, in example (18), the translators have decided to include the adjective “fateful” even though no elements in the original text denote such meaning. This is again an addition that seeks to compensate for those aspects of the Japanese text that might go missing in the translation.

- (18) a. *Sayō,* *ima=wo* *saru-koto* *ni-shūkan-mae...*
 So now=ACC pass-NOM two-week-before
 ‘So, two weeks ago...’
 b. Ah, yes. It was two **fateful** weeks ago...’

In short, English does not allow the depiction of old characters in a way as unequivocal as in Japanese, but it possesses some traits that the translator can make use of when trying to replicate the implications of this role language.

4.4 *Aruyo kotoba* and broken Japanese

Finally, we will look at the role language used by the Chinese characters in *Ranma ½* (the Jusenkyo guide and Shampoo). Unlike the previous cases analysed in this paper, these two characters’ speech styles are rendered in the translation following a clear strategy, which consists of the simplification of grammar. The example provided by the Jusenkyo guide (19) illustrates this.

- (19) a. *Ni-hyaku-nen-mae* *panda=ga* *obore-ta=[to]=iu*
 Two-hundred-year-before panda=NOM drown-PST=QUOT=say
 higeki-teki *densetsu=ga* *aru=no-da-yo*
 tragic-ATTR legend=NOM exist=NOM-COP-PRT

<i>Irai</i>	<i>soko=de</i>	<i>obore-ta</i>	<i>mono</i>	<i>mina</i>
henceforth	there=LOC	drown-PST	person	all
<i>panda=no</i>	<i>sugata=ni</i>	<i>nat-[t]eshimau</i>	<i>noroi-teki</i>	<i>izumi!</i>
panda =GEN	form=DAT	become-PRF	curse-ATTR	spring.

‘There is a tragic legend of a panda that drowned there two hundred years ago. It is a cursed spring where everybody who drowns there transforms into a panda!’

- b. “There is very tragic legend of panda... who drowned there two thousand year ago! Now whoever fall in that spring... take body of panda!”

As per the passage, the English text resorts to the omission of the “-s” in the third person singular, the plural form, and articles. Authors such as Fukushima (2012) and de Nazareth (2019) have also reached similar conclusions when analysing the language of the *ijin*, as they agree that Asian characters’ language in fiction is normally characterized by the use of the infinitive form of verbs, the deletion of articles, and the confusion between the letters “L” and “R”. It is remarkable here that the translators of *Ranma ½* have not utilized the resource of a poor pronunciation in the English text, even though it is conventionally linked to stereotypically foreign characters in media.

Shampoo has been treated similarly to the Jusenkyo guide, as shown in excerpt (20), repeated from §3.

- (20) a. *Anata=[wa]* *onna-teki* *Ranma=[wo]* *korosu.* *Watashi=[wa]*
 2.SG=TOP woman-ATTR Ranma=ACC kill 1.SG=TOP
- 119-shampoo=[wo]* *watasu.* *Kōkan-jōken.* *Yoku*
 119-shampoo=ACC give exchange-condition well
- wakara-nai=kedo* *waka[t]-ta.*
 understand-NEG=but understand-PST

‘If you kill female Ranma, I’ll give you shampoo 119. These are the conditions for exchange. I don’t understand, but got it’. (lit. ‘You kill female Ranma. I give you shampoo 119. Conditions for exchange. I don’t understand, but understood.’.

- b. “You kill female Ranma. I give you shampoo #911. Is deal? I don't understand... but is deal!”

Along with simplified grammar, another feature emerges as distinctive in Shampoo’s broken Japanese, namely the inclusion of her mother tongue. Chinese words are preserved in the translation, but in their Romanized version, as in the case of *wo da airen, ni hao, wo ai ni, bie liao*, etc. Dissimilarly, the elision of geminate consonants and long vowels in the original is not recreated in the English text. This is compensated for in other parts of the text and through different linguistic means.

5 Conclusion

In this paper, the Japanese and English versions of the first four volumes of Rumiko Takahashi’s *Ranma ½* have been revisited from the perspective of role language, with the aim of understanding the connection between the degree of role language in the original and the likelihood of a concrete speech style being recreated in a foreign language.

Role language consists of a set of language features that are psychologically bonded to a specific character type in fiction, rooted in a series of social stereotypes engendered in a given language community. Thus, it is a multidimensional phenomenon in which language, culture, and social beliefs cross paths. This complicates the translation task, as it becomes almost impossible to convey the meaning of the original text, not only from one language to another but from one culture to another in a faithful way.

This paper has focused on five types of role language: “male language”, “female language”, “elderly male language”, “*aruyo kotoba*”, and “broken Japanese”. Of these, “male language” and “female language” provide little information regarding the speaker and, accordingly, their “role language degree” is low. Conversely, “elderly male language”, “*aruyo kotoba*” and “broken Japanese” depict a more concrete character type, which entails a higher degree of role language. When checking this concept against the classification of characters by “classes” proposed by Kinsui (2017), we understand that, of all the characters in *Ranma ½*, those allocated to Class 2 and Class 3 (secondary or background characters) showed a tendency toward a more exaggerated use of role language than those identified as protagonists. This can be explained by resorting to the dual process model of impression formation by Brewer (1988), which states that a classification under stereotypes functions as a tool to economize the information processing task when the relationship between the perceiver and the target does not call for a deep understanding of each other. In line with this, it is not surprising that a “category-based” description is chosen for background characters, whereas Class 1 characters are described using a language closer to the standard, as readers need to grasp the protagonists’ psyches and self-identify with them fully.

When examining the English translation, it was seen that there might be a correlation between the “role language degree” of the characters in the original work and the extent to which the different speech styles have been reflected in the target text.

Thus, in the case of “male language” and “female language”, it is believed that there is no direct equivalent in English. Of course, this may be explained by the nature of the English language itself, which does not allow the identification of a specific gender through the use of personal pronouns or final particles, but also because speaking differences by gender might not be regarded as a configuring element of English fictionalized orality.

However, the characters’ colloquial register has been reproduced by the use of contractions and phrasal verbs, which suggests that whereas gender is complicated to convey, register is a parameter easier to replicate. Also, for those characters who, within the scope of “male language” and “female language”, show unique traits such as the use of old-fashioned expressions or extremely embellished words, other strategies have been observed. These include the use of literary terms, uncommon wording, expressions that denote a certain degree of formality, and the repeated use of a specific adjective, among others. Something similar was observed in the case of the “elderly male language”. Even though there is no direct translation for this role language, a similar impression as in the original may be achieved through the use of words consistent with an elaborated speech style.

By contrast, “*aruyo kotoba*” and “broken Japanese” (role language traditionally associated with the stereotypical figure of the foreigner in fiction) show the highest “role language degree” of all in the analysis. The speaking manner of the two Chinese characters in *Ranma ½* is conveyed by the simplification of grammar (omission of the -s in the third person singular, the plural form, and articles), in addition to the use of Romanized Chinese words in the case of the “broken Japanese” used by Shampoo. One remarkable aspect of the translation is the fact that an incorrect pronunciation (such as the confusion between “R” and “L” for Asian characters) was not employed as a strategy here. This could be a conscious decision by the translators to prevent the perpetuation of stereotypes.

In conclusion, it may be said that for speech styles with a low role language degree (such as the traditional “male language” or “female language”) the solutions in the translation are equally subtle, and the character type sketched in the original mostly fades out in the English version. However, slightly higher role language degree types (“elderly male language”) and very high role language degree types (“*aruyo kotoba*”, or “broken Japanese”) call for a more exaggerated conveyance of the speaking manner in the target text. The reason for this cannot be explained by simply resorting to the linguistic differences between Japanese and English, but it also relates to the literary tradition and the existing archetypes in both cultures. “Male language” and “female language” are associated with something as universal and easy to grasp as gender, so minor actions are required from the part of the translator for that character to be understood in foreign cultures. Conversely, a speech style marked as the stereotypical speaking manner of a Chinese person in Japanese might not be understood as easily, so bigger changes will be necessary for a correct comprehension of the character type. This seems to match Bun’s (2018: 35) findings concerning the relationship between role language degree and translation:

About those role languages with a low “role language degree”, such as “female language” or “elderly language”, even if the way they are expressed varies depending on the language, the character type described exists in virtually any society. Contrary to this, role languages like “samurai language” are bonded to character types that are only understood in Japan, and their “role language degree” is high, so it will be necessary a major effort on the part of the translator to lessen the difference in terms of stereotypes that might be between two cultures, and, the translation task will be, accordingly, more complicated.

After revising the conveyance (and non-conveyance) of the different speech styles into English, it is believed that when facing this task, the translators have mainly employed “compensation”, understood by Newmark (1988: 90) as “[a phenomenon that] occur[s] when loss of meaning, sound-effect, metaphor or pragmatic effect in one part of a sentence is compensated in another part, or in a contiguous sentence”. In *Ranma ½* “compensation in place” (the translation loss is made up for in a different place than in the original text) and “compensation in kind” (the translation loss is made up for by using different means than those observed in the source text) were especially frequent (see Harvey 1998).

This paper has only focused on one *manga*, so the findings might not apply to other cases. This limitation highlights the need for future research that examines more than one genre and language, making use of a broader sample. Such studies could reflect more deeply upon how significantly observed translation strategies are influenced by “the role language degree” used by the characters and their part in the storyline.

List of Abbreviations

1	first person	M	masculine
2	second person	NEG	negative
ACC	accusative	NOM	nominalizer
ATTR	attributive	ONOM	onomatopoeia
BEN	benefactive	PRF	perfect
COND	conditional	PRT	particle
COP	copula	TAG	tag question
DAT	dative	PST	past
GEN	genitive	Q	question
GER	gerund	QUOT	quotative
HON	honorific	SG	singular
IMP	imperative	TOP	topic
INTJ	interjection	VOL	volitional
LOC	locative		

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